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Practice Peer-graded Assignment: Audience/Context/Culture

Compare your critique for this assignment with the instructor version below.

Instructor Critique: American Express Open commercial

by Yasmin Gibson

PROMPT

Which design work from the provided list are you analyzing?

American Express Open Commercial

PROMPT

What is the **function** of the work? Rate it based on the Critique Framework and provide an explanation for your rating.

The function of the commercial is **strong/clear.** The function of the work is to promote and inform the audience about American Express services and products for business. The commercial clearly presents American Express' visual identity and explains that the company helps businesses of all sizes grow and evolve.

PROMPT

Who is the work's **audience**? Rate how well the work addresses its audience using the Critique Framework. Be sure to provide an explanation for your rating.

It is **clear** who the audience is because the commercial clearly identifies small and large businesses as its target audience. Based on the framework, one might try to make the case that the audience is fair/understandable because the commercial only speaks to one audience and does not go beyond that audience. In this case, however, because the services American Express offers

would be suited to groups outside small and large businesses, it would be confusing if the commercial addressed additional audiences.

PROMPT

What is the **main theme or concept** of the work? Describe it by either paraphrasing, or quoting from the work itself or from its description. Be sure the rate the work using the Critique Framework and provide an explanation for your rating.

The main theme or concept of the work is **strong/clear**. The main concept is stated in the opening line of the commercial: "the old way of working doesn't work anymore." The commercial goes on to list and represent various new ways of working and how American Express supports them.

PROMPT

Identify a **visual language** from the work and describe how it is used.

The uses of visual languages are **strong/clear**.

There are three identifiable visual languages used in this commercial:

1/ Op Art
Definitions and visual reference are available here:
http://www.op-art.co.uk
https://www.tate.org.uk/art/art-terms/o/op-art
The visual language of Op Art is used primarily for transitions. For example, at time code 00:16, where one thing (the portrait of the centurion) transforms into Op Art striped bands, then separate into lines and finally into outline silhouettes. Another example is at time code 00:25, where Op Art boxes transform into a globe / sphere. The characteristic high contrast stripes of Op Art are a visually similar, modern interpretation of the fine engraving lines that are part of American Express' visual identity.

2/ Information Graphics
The visual language of charts, diagrams and graphs is commonly associated with business presentations. For example at time code 00:03, the tangled line transforms into a map of the world with locations plotted on it. The next scene transitions to a diagram of a maze / brain and the movement of ideas through it, and finally into a series of arrows moving upward, reminding us of growth on a chart.

3/ Currency / Certificates
Visual reference is available here:
http://www.traveller.org/currency/

Filigree or fine engraving is characteristic of the visual language of currency and certificates. It suggests not only a sense of officialness, but also of stability, tradition and security. We see it in the centurion image at time code 00:15, and also referenced later in the American Express pattern at time code 00:24 and the "1850" at 00:32.

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Practice Peer-graded Assignment: Audience/Context/Culture

Compare your critique for this assignment with the instructor version below.

Instructor Critique: Whitney Identity

by Yasmin Gibson

PROMPT

Which design work from the provided list are you analyzing?

Whitney Identity

PROMPT

What is the **function** of the work? Rate it based on the Critique Framework and provide an explanation for your rating.

The function of the identity is **strong/clear.** The function is to present a distinctive and responsive visual identity for the Whitney Museum. The identity presents the museum as a modern institution with an ever-changing collection and slate of exhibitions.

PROMPT

Who is the work's **audience**? Rate how well the work addresses its audience using the Critique Framework. Be sure to provide an explanation for your rating.

It is **clear** who the audience is because the identity appeals to both traditional patrons in its use of tasteful, minimal elements that seem appropriate for a serious art institution and to more progressive patrons in the responsive, unconventional behavior of the identity system's elements. The identity speaks to more than one group at the same time.

PROMPT

What is the **main theme or concept** of the work? Describe it by either paraphrasing, or quoting from the work itself or from its description. Be sure the rate the work using the Critique Framework and provide an explanation for your rating.

The main theme or concept of the identity is **strong/clear**: the Whitney is always evolving and responding to shifts in culture and ideas.

PROMPT

Identify a **visual language** from the work and describe how it is used.

The use of the visual language of high modernism is **clear/strong**.

The visual language can be see in these examples:

- The minimal color palette (black and white)
- The mono-weight W and sans serif typography
- Asymmetrically balanced compositions
- The use of the modular grid (with the exception of the responsive W)